

CMS.100: Theories of media

From last time: what is theory? Why is it important? → exploratory and explanatory functions

Marshall McLuhan, *The Medium is the Message*

- Electronic interdependence (and “surfing”)
- Global village
- Technological determinism
 - Ontology: study of existence or being
 - Epistemology: study of knowledge
 - Axiology: study of values

Walter Benjamin, “The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction”

- Industrial production
- Aura

Stuart Hall, “Encoding / Decoding”

- Producers encode meanings
- Audiences decode meaning from their social positions

These are some “traditional” theories, we’ll explore more as the class goes on...

CMS.100: Print culture

Actor’s categories vs. historical anachronisms

Information, data, knowledge, evidence, facts...

Discussion: What are the different dimensions of the argument in *Too Much to Know*?

- **Ontological:** what “counts” as data or information?
- **Epistemological:** how does she know what she knows? Methods?
- **Axiological:** are books, knowledge, information, etc. value neutral?

For next time: how do you classify, organize, or search for information?